

Reading

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Life Aboard the Space Station

Before you read

- Look at the title. What do you think an astronaut's daily routine looks like?
- Guess: how many hours a day do you think astronauts spend exercising?

My name is Commander Lena Voss, and I have been living on the International Research Station for four months. By the end of this mission, I will have spent almost a year of my life in zero gravity.

Every morning starts the same way. I check my spacesuit, talk to mission control, and review the day's tasks. Without gravity, even simple things like eating breakfast or brushing your teeth become a small adventure — food floats if you're not careful!

In the afternoon, we usually run experiments. Right now, we are growing plants to see if a colony on the Moon could one day grow its own food. By the time I return to Earth, our team will have completed over two hundred experiments.

Exercise is extremely important here. Without it, our muscles and bones become weak in zero gravity, so we exercise for two hours every day. By the end of my mission, I will have been exercising on this station for almost a thousand hours.

In the evening, I like to look out of the window at Earth. It's easy to forget how small our planet looks from up here. I always remind the younger astronauts: by the time your first mission ends, you will have seen more sunrises than most people see in a lifetime — the station orbits the Earth every ninety minutes!

Life here isn't always easy, but I wouldn't change it. When people ask if it's worth it, I always say the same thing: humans will have learned enough about long space missions by the 2030s to finally send astronauts to Mars — and I want to be part of that story.

1. What is the text mainly about?
 - a. The history of space stations
 - b. An astronaut's daily life and future plans
 - c. How rockets are built
2. How long has Lena already been on the station?
 - a. Four months
 - b. A year
 - c. Two hundred days
3. Why does Lena exercise every day?
 - a. To feel less bored
 - b. Because her muscles and bones become weak in zero gravity
 - c. Because mission control tells her to compete

4. What are the astronauts growing plants for?

- a. To decorate the station
- b. To test food for a possible Moon colony
- c. To sell them on Earth

5. The space station orbits the Earth once a day. — True / False

6. How does Lena probably feel about her life on the station?

- a. Regretful
- b. Proud and hopeful about the future of space travel
- c. Bored

After you read

- By the end of Lena's mission, what will she have done? Write two sentences with the Future Perfect.
- Would you like to live on a space station for a year? Why or why not?

Our Mars Colony Project

Before you read

- What do you think people would need to survive on Mars?
- Guess: what jobs might people have in a colony on another planet?

For our class project this term, we designed a hypothetical colony on Mars. First, we had to decide who would live there: scientists, engineers, doctors, and farmers who could grow food in a sustainable way.

We predicted that by 2100, the first colony will have grown from just a few hundred people to a small, functioning town. Our group decided the colony would need its own sustainable energy system, because sending fuel from Earth would be far too expensive.

One of the biggest challenges was breathing. Mars doesn't have enough oxygen, so every building needs a special system. We imagined that by the time the colony celebrates its fiftieth anniversary, engineers will have developed advanced technology to make the air completely safe, even outside the main buildings.

We also wrote short scripts for our presentation. In one scene, a scientist explains a new breakthrough in growing food on Mars; in another, two astronauts argue about whether humans should build more colonies or focus on protecting Earth instead.

Working on this project taught us that interplanetary travel isn't just about rockets and spacesuits — it's also about people, teamwork, and difficult decisions. We will have learned a lot more about ourselves than about Mars by the time we finish presenting our project to the class!

1. What was the class project about?

- a. Building a real spacecraft
- b. Designing a hypothetical colony on Mars
- c. Writing a report about the Moon

2. Why does the colony need its own sustainable energy system?

- a. Because sending fuel from Earth would be too expensive
- b. Because Mars is too cold
- c. Because the colony has no engineers

3. What is one of the biggest challenges for the colony, according to the text?

- a. Finding water
- b. Breathing, because Mars doesn't have enough oxygen
- c. Building roads

4. What do the two astronauts argue about in the script?

- a. Who should be the leader
- b. Whether to build more colonies or protect Earth instead
- c. What to eat for dinner

5. The students think their project was only about rockets and spacesuits. — *True / False*

6. What can we infer about the writer's opinion of the project?

- a. It was a waste of time
- b. It was a valuable and interesting learning experience
- c. It was too easy

After you read

- What job would you choose in a Mars colony? Explain why in two sentences.
- Write one prediction about Mars colonies using the Future Perfect, e.g. 'By 2100, ...'